The Dubai Budget Planner

A side-by-side UK vs Dubai cost comparison for the 2026 expat

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Dubai Budget Planner UK vs Dubai Monthly Cost Comparison dubaiexpat.co.uk This planner compares typical monthly costs between the UK and Dubai across the categories that matter most. The 'Your Budget' column is for your own figures — fill it in as you research to build a realistic picture of what your move will actually cost. All figures in AED. Approximate conversion: 1 GBP = 4.7 AED. Housing (Monthly) Category UK Typical Dubai Typical Your Budget 1-bed apartment (city centre) 5,600 - 8,500 5,000 - 9,000 2-bed apartment (city centre) 8,000 - 14,000 7,500 - 14,000 3-bed villa (suburbs) 11,000 - 19,000 10,000 - 18,000 Housing deposit 4-5 weeks rent 5% annual rent Agency fee (one-off) N/A 5% annual rent Dubai rents are paid by cheque — 1 to 4 cheques per year. Budget for the first cheque upfront. Utilities (Monthly) Category UK Typical Dubai Typical Your Budget Electricity + water 700 - 1,000 400 - 1,200 Air conditioning (DEWA) Included above 300 - 900 Internet (fibre) 200 - 280 350 - 500 Mobile plan 100 - 200 150 - 350 Total Utilities 1,000 - 1,480 1,200 - 2,950 AC is the big variable — a villa in summer can triple your DEWA bill. Transport (Monthly) Category UK Typical Dubai Typical Your Budget Car loan / lease 800 - 1,600 1,000 - 2,500 Fuel 500 - 700 300 - 500 Insurance (monthly equiv.) 200 - 450 150 - 350 Salik tolls + parking N/A 200 - 500 Public transport (metro/bus) 350 - 700 200 - 400 Total Transport (car) 1,500 - 2,750 1,650 - 3,850 Fuel is significantly cheaper in Dubai. Insurance too — but Salik tolls add up quickly. Food & Groceries (Monthly) Category UK Typical Dubai Typical Your Budget Groceries (family of 2) 1,400 - 2,300 1,500 - 2,800 Eating out (mid-range, 2 ppl) 350 - 500 per meal 250 - 450 per meal Coffee (flat white) 18 - 22 18 - 25 Alcohol (supermarket, 6-pack) 30 - 50 70 - 120 Total Food (couple, moderate) 2,500 - 3,800 2,800 - 4,500 Groceries are comparable but imported UK brands cost more. Alcohol is 2-3x UK prices. Education — School Fees (Annual, converted to monthly) Category UK Typical Dubai Typical Your Budget Primary (state / public) Free N/A (all private) Primary (private / British curriculum) 2,000 - 4,500/mo 2,500 - 5,000/mo Secondary (private / British curriculum) 3,000 - 6,000/mo 3,500 - 8,000/mo Nursery (full-time) 2,500 - 5,000/mo 2,000 - 5,500/mo There are no free state schools for expats in Dubai. Budget for school fees from day one. Healthcare (Monthly) Category UK Typical Dubai Typical Your Budget Usually Health insurance (employer) Free (NHS + top-up) employer-covered Health insurance (self-employed) 500 - 1,200 400 - 1,500 GP visit (out of pocket) 200 - 400 200 - 500 Dental check-up 250 - 500 300 - 600 Employer-sponsored visas must include health insurance by law. Freelancers need to budget for it. Lifestyle & Leisure (Monthly) Category UK Typical Dubai Typical Your Budget Gym membership 150 - 300 200 - 500 Cinema (2 tickets) 60 - 90 70 - 100 Beach club day pass N/A 150 - 500 Weekend brunch (per person) N/A 200 - 500 Domestic cleaner (weekly) 200 - 400 300 - 500 Dubai's social scene revolves around brunches and beach clubs — budget accordingly. Your Monthly Summary Category UK Cost Dubai Cost Difference Housing Utilities Transport Food & Groceries Education Healthcare Lifestyle & Leisure Savings / Investments TOTAL MONTHLY COST One-Off Relocation Costs (Don't Forget These) Item Typical Cost (AED) Your Cost Visa + medical + Emirates ID 3,500 - 7,000 Security deposit (DEWA) 2,000 Housing deposit (5% of annual rent) Varies Shipping (20ft container, UK to Dubai) 8,000 - 15,000 Flights (one-way, family of 2-4) 3,000 - 10,000 Furniture / fit-out (if unfurnished) 5,000 - 25,000 Car purchase or deposit 5,000 - 20,000 School registration + deposit 2,000 - 8,000 Budget Tips for New Arrivals The two-cheque trap: Your first year's rent is typically paid in 1-4 post-dated cheques. If your landlord wants one cheque, you need the full year upfront. Negotiate for 4 cheques. DEWA deposit: AED 2,000 refundable deposit for electricity and water. Required before you move in. No income tax: Your gross salary IS your take-home. But factor in the costs that the UK covers via tax — healthcare, pension, and school fees are now on you. Summer AC bills: June-September can double or triple your DEWA bill. Budget AED 800-2,000/month for a 2-bed apartment in peak summer. Car is essential: Dubai is not walkable outside Downtown/Marina. Budget for a car from day one unless you're living and working on the Metro line. Alcohol licence: You need a personal alcohol licence to

buy from shops (free, but apply early). Restaurant/bar prices are 2-4x UK prices. Created by dubaiexpat.co.uk — The expat's guide to moving from the UK to Dubai. This document is for general guidance only. Costs vary by lifestyle, location, and family size. All figures approximate as of April 2026. Conversion: 1 GBP » 4.7 AED.